

CORE FORMULA

Reduce the effort: "If it's easy, could you send the link?" -> **Reduce the ambiguity:** "A yes or no is all I need." -> **Give an easy path to reply:** "A one-line answer is plenty." -> **Make no genuinely acceptable:** "No worries at all if not."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Add one small easing clause to your request — "if it's easy" or "no worries if not" — that makes a genuine no just as available as a yes.

BEST FOR

- Busy people who are short on time
- Optional help or small favours
- Weak ties and first-time asks
- Quick replies where a full discussion is overkill
- Reducing the decision effort for the other person
- Digital and async requests
- Chasing something without adding pressure

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Starter one-liners

- "If it's easy, could you send the link? No worries if not."
- "A yes or no is completely fine."
- "No need for detail — a quick answer is plenty."
- "If now's not a good time, just leave it."
- "Whenever suits — no rush at all."
- "Two-second question, if you have it to hand."
- "Only if it's quick."
- "Genuinely happy to be told no."

Warm & optional · Low-pressure warmth

- "No worries at all if you'd rather not."
- "Genuinely fine either way."
- "Please don't go out of your way for this."
- "If it's a faff, forget it — it's not urgent."
- "I'd love your help, but only if it's easy for you."
- "No pressure — I just thought I'd ask."
- "You'd be doing me a favour, but a no is completely fine."

Work & professional · Meetings, email, clients

- "If you have 30 seconds, could you point me to the right person?"
- "A one-line reply is all I need."
- "Whenever it's convenient this week is fine."
- "Feel free to forward this on if someone else is better placed."
- "If it's already to hand, could you share it? If not, I'll dig it out."
- "No need to write it up — a quick steer is enough."
- "If this isn't your area, just say and I'll ask elsewhere."

The clean ask · Ask plus an easy path

- "Could you send me the link when you get a moment?"
- "Can you point me to the file? A link is fine."
- "Would a yes/no work for now, with the detail later?"
- "Could you confirm the date? One word is plenty."
- "If it's easy, could you approve this today? If not, tomorrow's fine."
- "Just the headline is enough — could you give me that?"

Digital / text · Async, one clean line

- "To make sure I'm chasing the right thing — is it the March version you need?"
- "Quick one: do you still have the deck? A link's perfect."
- "No reply needed if it's already sorted."
- "A thumbs-up is a fine answer."
- "Reply whenever — I've set it aside, not waiting on it."
- "If it's easier to send a screenshot than explain, that works too."

When it lands heavy · Softening & recovery

- "Sorry — that came out more urgent than I meant. Genuinely no rush."
- "Ignore the deadline I put on that; whenever is fine."
- "Let me put that more simply."
- "No need to answer that if it's not useful."
- "I jumped ahead there — please leave it if it's awkward."
- "Forget I asked — I'll find another route."

Guarded or senior · Power imbalance

- "Useful if I check the premise before I respond, or would you rather I just read it?"
- "Only if you're comfortable — no obligation either way."
- "You're well within your rights to say no to this."
- "I'd rather you said no than felt cornered into a yes."
- "Take your time; there's no clock on this from my end."
- "If it's not appropriate to ask, just tell me and I'll drop it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Can you do this for me? It'll only take a second.
Better: If it's easy, could you send me the link? No worries if not.
Best: If it's easy and you've got it nearby, could you send the link? If it'd take digging, please leave it.
2. Weak: Just following up again — I really need this today.
Better: No rush, but if it's to hand, could you send it over?
Best: Whenever suits — a link is plenty, and if someone else is better placed, feel free to pass it on.
3. Weak: Have you had a chance to look at my email yet?
Better: When you get a moment, a yes/no on this would really help.
Best: No urgency — a one-line steer is all I need, and a no is completely fine.

DECISION TREE

If They're still speaking

Wait — don't drop the ask into the middle of their point.

If The ask is unclear

Use a check version before you ask for anything.

"Just so I ask for the right thing — is it the March file you mean?"

If They seem to resist or hesitate

Validate the concern first, then lighten the ask.

"Totally fair if it's a hassle — no obligation."

If They'd clearly rather decide for themselves

Ask permission before offering help or advice.

"Want a suggestion, or would you rather run with it?"

If The move increased ease

Continue — the exchange is flowing.

If The move reduced ease

Repair or release the ask.

"Forget it for now — I'll find another route."

SCENARIOS

Social

Keep it warm and brief; make the invitation easy to decline. — "If you're free, fancy grabbing a coffee? No worries if the week's mad."

Professional

Name the action or concern clearly, then cap the effort. — "If you've got the figures to hand, could you send them? If not, I'll pull them myself."

Digital / text

Write one clean sentence and avoid overexplaining. — "Quick one — do you still have the deck? A link's perfect."

Conflict or objection

Validate or summarise before you make any ask. — "I think I've got your main worry — can I check I've got it right before I respond?"

High-status or guarded person

Make the move optional and low-pressure. — "Only if it's useful — would a quick premise-check help, or shall I just read it?"

Close relationship

Use ordinary language; don't sound like a technique. — "If you're passing the shop, grab milk? Totally fine if not."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The ask has real stakes that need a full, honest discussion.
- Saying no would be socially risky for them.
- The other person has less power, so "optional" may not feel optional.
- Direct, open negotiation would be more respectful.
- Making it "easy" would hide a genuine cost of saying yes.
- Physical safety or an emergency needs a plain, direct request instead.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the friction

Notice three requests you make today and mark which ones felt heavy or awkward to answer.

Day 2 — Name the cue

For five recent conversations, write the cue you missed where a lighter ask would have helped.

Day 3 — Draft the line

Rewrite one of those asks as a single plain sentence with a genuine exit, e.g. "...no worries if not".

Day 4 — Say it aloud

Rehearse your line until it stops sounding scripted, and cut any word that quietly adds pressure.

Day 5 — Add the fallback

Practise the "best" version: cap the effort ("if it's to hand") and offer a real alternative route.

Day 6 — Field test

Use one low-friction ask in a real conversation and note the calibration cue you saw in reply.

Day 7 — Repair rep

Deliberately over-ask, then practise a recovery line until releasing the ask feels natural.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the cue and pause before the reflex ask?
- Was the move short and in plain language?
- Did I leave a genuine, cost-free way to say no?
- Did I check rather than assume what they needed?
- Did I watch their response and calibrate?
- Did I repair quickly if it landed heavy?